

Uniform MDT (U-MDT) and Current Treatment Recommendations

At present, the WHO recommends **Uniform MDT (U-MDT)** — a 6-month treatment with **rifampicin (RMP)**, **dapsone**, and **clofazimine** — for all forms of leprosy, regardless of classification. This approach eliminates the need to differentiate between paucibacillary (PB) and multibacillary (MB) disease. However, this recommendation is controversial and has been questioned and strongly opposed by many clinicians.

Efficacy and Safety of MDT Components

The traditional MDT regimens have demonstrated high efficacy with very low relapse rates (approximately 4%). However, in multibacillary leprosy, follow-up periods are often too short to fully assess long-term outcomes.

Dapsone Considerations

- **Caution is advised with dapsone use in Nordic Caucasians**, who are prone to haemolysis even with normal G6PD status.
- A reduced dose of **50 mg daily** appears effective in most patients and significantly reduces the risk of anaemia, likely due to genetic factors.
- **Nepalese and Chinese patients** have an increased risk of developing **dapsone hypersensitivity syndrome** and require careful monitoring.

Alternative Regimens

Single-Lesion Leprosy

For single-lesion paucibacillary leprosy, a **single-dose regimen** of **rifampicin**, **ofloxacin**, and **minocycline (ROM)** was previously advocated. While convenient, this regimen proved less effective than standard WHO-MDT.

Monthly ROM Regimen

ROM was also tested as a monthly regimen for both tuberculoid and lepromatous leprosy but showed inferior efficacy compared to WHO-recommended MDT.

Table 1: WHO-Recommended Treatment of Leprosy

Age group	Drug	Dosage and frequency	Duration (MB)	Duration (PB)
Adult	Rifampicin	600 mg once a month	12 months	6 months
	Clofazimine	300 mg once a month and 50 mg daily		
Children (10–14 years)	Rifampicin	450 mg once a month	12 months	6 months
	Clofazimine	150 mg once a month and 50 mg daily		
Children (<10 years or <40 kg)	Rifampicin	10 mg/kg once a month	12 months	6 months
	Clofazimine	6 mg/kg once a month and 1 mg/kg daily		
	Dapsone	2 mg/kg daily		

Table 2: Treatment of Resistant Leprosy (WHO)

Resistance type	First 6 months (daily)	Next 18 months (daily)
Rifampicin resistance	Levofloxacin 500 mg + minocycline 100 mg + clofazimine 50 mg	Levofloxacin 500 mg OR minocycline 100 mg + clofazimine 50 mg
	Levofloxacin 500 mg + minocycline 500 mg + clofazimine 50 mg	Levofloxacin 500 mg + clofazimine 50 mg
Rifampicin and ofloxacin resistance	Clarithromycin 500 mg + minocycline 100 mg + clofazimine 50 mg	Clarithromycin 500 mg OR minocycline 100 mg + clofazimine 50 mg